remember much of my initial interview, except that the CO seemed to be reading a novel while in office. The Adjutant was Capt AVS Ghuman, a stern officer who we youngsters were fearful of—even more than the CO. We were at the fag-end of our tenure and due to move from the icy heights of Sikkim to Bikaner, to the deserts of Rajasthan. In fact, the advance party had already moved to Bikaner, to 'take over' from the unit there, just like we were 'handing over' to the incoming unit at Gangtok. This 'handing/taking over' between units was and still is a most tedious, and more often than not, acrimonious process. The unit doing the taking over behaves like the 'boy's side' (in a wedding), making life difficult for the handing-over unit, which is like the 'girl's side', who wants to complete the process at the earliest and move out from a hard field (operational) area to a peace station and be with their families.

On joining the paltan, I was assigned to Alpha Company where Subedar Dilbagh Singh 'Communist' was the Senior JCO (junior commissioned officer). Why he had been nicknamed 'Communist', I never did figure out. Dilbagh Sahib (as the JCOs are respectfully addressed), was at the forefront of the handing/taking over for the Company. My role in the handing/taking over was to sign the rum *parchis* (requisitions) that Dilbagh Sahib used to present to me every morning, giving me some report in '*thhet*' (rustic) Punjabi to which I would nod my head knowingly. I hadn't the faintest idea of what he was saying or of what he did with the rum—how much was bartered, how much went down the hatch. All I know is that 'A' Company was the first to give the 'All OK' report of completion of the handing/taking over. Since we were on the way out, the Battalion had come back from the border and concentrated at Gangtok. As part of the handing over, I accompanied the CO to Nagchok, which had been one of our Company posts, in a

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